

The Business Across a Lifetime

Career stages, self-employed leave planning, and passing a practice on with intention

Learning Objectives

- Describe the typical career-stage progression from solo starter to salon owner or mentor
- Plan for maternity or extended leave as a self-employed practitioner
- Explain the basics of succession and retirement planning for a salon owner
- Apply the lifetime-adaptation principle taught in earlier courses to the business itself

A career, not just a job

Just as Course VI and Course VII taught you to adapt a service for a client at any life stage, this module teaches you to adapt your own business as your own life stage changes — a solo starter's needs differ genuinely from a decade-established owner's, and pretending otherwise leads to avoidable financial and personal strain.

The typical progression

- **Solo starter.** Building a client base, often within an employee or booth-rental model from Module Two.
- **Established independent.** A steady, self-sustaining practice, potentially the point of transition to a solo studio.
- **Team lead or salon owner.** Managing other practitioners, taking on the operations and compliance weight of Module Eleven.
- **Mentor or trainer.** Passing skill forward, the stage this entire Atelier itself exists within.

Planning for leave as a self-employed practitioner

Unlike a salaried employee, a self-employed practitioner's income typically stops the moment she does — making deliberate advance planning for maternity leave, medical leave, or any extended absence a genuine financial necessity, not an afterthought. Build a dedicated leave fund well ahead of when it might be needed, and, if operating a team, cross-train at least one other practitioner who can maintain key client relationships during any owner's absence.

Succession and retirement planning

A salon owner's practice, built over years, represents both an income source and, potentially, a saleable or transferable asset. Begin succession conversations years, not months, before a planned exit — identifying and training a potential successor, documenting systems and client relationships so they do not leave with any single departing practitioner, and seeking professional guidance on valuing and structuring an eventual sale or transfer.

Key Terms

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Practical Activity · Map Your Own Stages

Map your own hypothetical career progression across the four stages in this module, and identify one specific planning step you would take to prepare for a future leave or eventual succession.